GENRE EXPLORATION

Pacing guide · 7 class periods

PACING

Teacher

7 class periods, as on my project menu. The “My plan” column is my day-by-day pacing guide as I wrote it; the other columns show what to put on the screen and in students’ hands.

CLASS	MY PLAN	TEACHER MOVES	DECK	STUDENT PAGES
CLASS 1	**Class 1:** Introduction. Select genre and begin Google Form research.	Slides 1–7: hook, what the project is, the five steps, four words to know, steps 1 and 2. Hand out the project sheet and the Genre research sheet. Approve each student’s genre before they leave.	Slides 1–7	p. 12, p. 16, p. 17, p. 18, p. 20
CLASS 2	**Class 2:** Finish research. Begin sketching an 8–16 bar loop.	Slides 8–10: a genre’s fingerprint, instruments are not enough, before you compose. Hand out the Reference track log and the Loop and form sketch. Check each research sheet for concrete elements.	Slides 8–10	p. 13, p. 14
CLASS 3	**Classes 3–5:** Working days — expand composition, refine arrangement and mix.	Slides 11–12: steps 3 and 4, and the worked example on paper. Hand out the Work plan. Then work time.	Slides 11–12	p. 15
CLASS 4		Slides 13–14: use your references constantly, and mix like the genre. Then work time.	Slides 13–14	p. 15
CLASS 5		Full working day: expand, refine, mix. Ask each student to play a reference and then their own track, and say what is different.	No new slides	—
CLASS 6	**Class 6:** Final mix, bounce, write reflection. Prepare presentations.	Slides 15–17: mix, reflect and bounce, what to turn in, the rubric. Students write the reflection paragraph (page 22) and post their three Padlet questions.	Slides 15–17	p. 22, p. 19, p. 21
CLASS 7	**Class 7:** Presentations with Padlet Q&A peer feedback.	Slides 18–19: presentation day and the close. Every student presents and answers 2 of each classmate’s questions.	Slides 18–19	p. 21

THE ONE RULE FOR CLASS 1

Approve every genre before the student leaves. If it is close to what they already make (my first struggle), ask: what would you not normally reach for?

CLASSES 3–5

Working days; Class 5 has no new slide. Circulate with one question: is that the instrument, or the production style?

PREVIEW

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GENRE EXPLORATION

Worked example · an invented genre

EXAMPLE

Teacher

An **invented genre, "Harbor Drift", with three invented reference tracks, described on paper**: no audio is included and no real genre is named. Students' projects will differ.

1 · A GENRE CARD ·

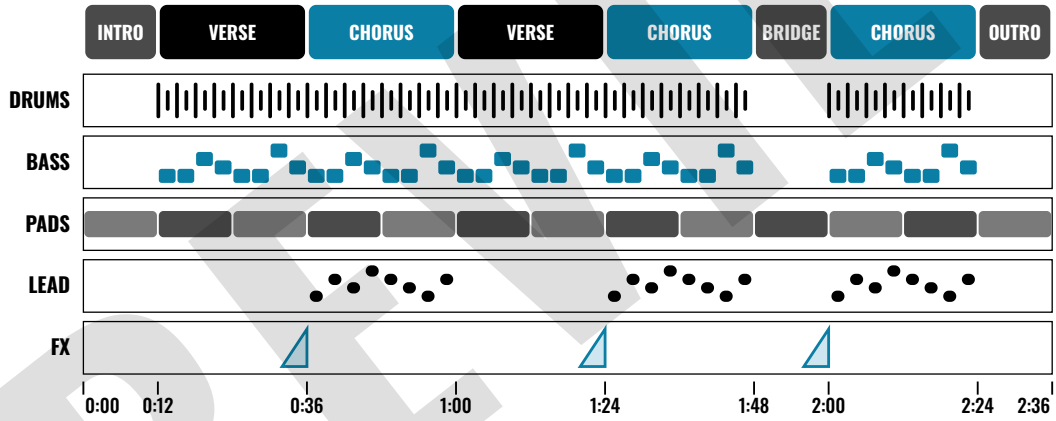
Tempo	about 76–84 beats per minute
Rhythm	soft kick on beats 1 and 3, light brushed hi-hat in eighth notes, no heavy snare
Instruments and sounds	wide warm pads, a plucked bass, a bell-like lead; no distorted guitars
Song form	intro, verse, chorus, verse, chorus, a short bridge, chorus, outro
Production style	lots of space: reverb on the pads, the drums' highs rolled off, the bass quiet and centered

2 · THREE REFERENCE TRACKS, BROKEN DOWN ·

TRACK	TEMPO	FORM	NOTES
Reference A	about 80 BPM	4 + 8 + 8 + 8 + 8 + 4 = 40 bars	starts with the pads alone
Reference B	about 84 BPM	4 + 8 + 8 + 8 + 8 + 8 + 4 = 48 bars	drums wait until the first verse
Reference C	about 76 BPM	4 + 8 + 8 + 4 + 8 + 8 + 4 = 44 bars	a short bridge before the last chorus

What they share: slow, spacious, the same section order, a short intro and a short bridge.

3 · THE ARRANGEMENT MAP: 2:36 ·



4 · CHECKING THE NUMBERS

80 beats per minute is 0.75 s a beat, so a bar of 4/4 is 3 s. Sections: 4 + 8 + 8 + 8 + 8 + 4 + 8 + 4 = 52 bars, and 52 × 3 s = 156 s = 2:36. It follows the form the three references share, and each chorus brings back the lead.

5 · INSTRUMENTS RIGHT, PRODUCTION WRONG?

Weak: I used pads, a bass and a bell. It is Harbor Drift.

Strong: The instruments are only half of Harbor Drift. The drums' highs are rolled off so they stay soft, the pads sit in a wide reverb while the bass stays dry and in the center, and the whole track is quiet and spacious like Reference A, B and C. I checked this by playing Reference A next to my track in Logic and matching the space.

6 · TWO GENRE-SPECIFIC MIXING TECHNIQUES (MY HARDER VARIATION)

Roll off the drums' highs	A gentle low-pass filter on the drums keeps the hi-hat soft, as in all three references.
Wide reverb on the pads only	A long reverb on the pads gives the space; the bass stays dry and centered so it is not washed out.

Three Padlet questions (invented): 1. Where did you first hear the track open up? 2. Which part would you turn up or down, and why? 3. Does it sound like the genre I described?

PREVIEW

GENRE EXPLORATION

Project sheet · requirements and steps

STUDENT

Name _____ Date _____

REQUIREMENTS ·

- ☐ Choose a genre you are NOT already comfortable producing in
- ☐ Complete the Genre Research Google Form before composing
- ☐ Your track should follow typical song forms and conventions of the genre
- ☐ Use instruments, synths, or samples authentic to the genre
- ☐ Apply genre-appropriate mixing and production techniques
- ☐ Write a short reflection (1 paragraph minimum) on what you learned

STEPS / PROCESS ·

1. **Research** — Select your genre and complete the Google Form analyzing its key characteristics (Genre research sheet: page 12)
2. **Listen** — Study 2–3 reference tracks and break down their elements (Reference track log: page 13)
3. **Sketch** — Build an 8–16 bar loop that captures the genre's essence (Loop and form sketch: page 14)
4. **Compose** — Develop the full song structure. Layer instrumentation and refine. (Work plan: page 15)
5. **Mix** — Apply genre-appropriate mixing techniques. Polish the track.
6. Write your reflection and finalize your bounce (Reflection: page 22)
7. **Present & Get Feedback** — Create your own Padlet post with 3 questions you want classmates to answer about your project. Present to the class. During classmates' presentations, answer at least 2 of their 3 questions on their Padlet post.

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GENRE EXPLORATION

RUBRIC

Rubric

/ 25

Name _____ Date _____

GRADING RUBRIC /25

Genre Exploration | Structured Project

Each category is scored 1–5. Your final grade is the average of your self-score and your teacher's score.

Category	1	2	3	4	5
CREATIVITY & ORIGINALITY	Minimal creative effort; relies on defaults or clichés	Some creative ideas but largely predictable	Shows originality; experiments with sound or style	Highly creative; unique approach with clear artistic intent	Exceptional creativity; innovative, bold, and expressive
TECHNICAL SKILL / DAW USE	Limited understanding of Logic Pro tools	Basic tool use with frequent errors	Competent workflow; uses tools correctly	Advanced use of Logic features and shortcuts	Expert-level command of multiple Logic systems
COMPOSITION & STRUCTURE	Disorganized; no clear form or direction	Some structure present but underdeveloped	Clear, cohesive form with logical sections	Engaging structure with dynamic progression	Professional pacing, flow, and musical arc
SOUND DESIGN & MIX QUALITY	Poor sound choices; unbalanced or muddy mix	Some variety but inconsistent levels and EQ	Good sound selection; mostly balanced mix	Strong sound palette; clean, well-balanced mix	Exceptional sound design; professional-quality mix
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	Missing or incomplete; no reflection	Minimal documentation with little insight	Satisfactory; provides basic detail and reflection	Well-documented; clear and thoughtful reflection	Exceptional; thorough insight and polished delivery

Student Score: _____ / 25	Teacher Score: _____ / 25
Final Grade = Average of Student + Teacher = _____ / 25	

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